IB English A: Language and Literature · Paper 2

Nineteen Eighty-Four

George Orwell · A Paper 2 guide

Comparative essay preparation
Event bank · Quote bank · Issue arcs by part and across the novel
Dig deeper · Self-test

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How to use this guide

References take the form 2.9 (40%): Part Two, Chapter 9, about 40 per cent of the way through the chapter, rounded to the nearest 5 per cent. “App” is the Appendix, “The Principles of Newspeak”. This works in any edition.

> **Built for Paper 2.** The issue arcs trace each concern through the novel’s three parts, and Dig deeper sets out readings to test against it.

The examination

Course and paper	IB Diploma English A: Language and Literature, Paper 2: the comparative essay on two literary works studied in the course. Paper 2 is not a set-text exam: the questions are general, they do not name any work, and there are no extracts.
Format	1 hour 45 minutes at both SL and HL. Answer one of four general questions, comparing two of the literary works you have studied. 25 marks.
Criteria	A Knowledge, understanding and interpretation (5). B Analysis and evaluation (10), in two strands: B1 how meaning is shaped by language, technique, style and broader authorial choices (5); B2 the similarities and differences between the two works (5). C Focus and organisation (5). D Language (5).
What this means for revision	You will not know the question in advance, so you cannot prepare a single essay. You prepare a small number of moments from each work that you know in detail, grouped by issue, and you rehearse how each work handles those issues differently. That is what the issue arcs, the event bank and the quote bank in this guide are for. Comparison must be structural: every paragraph needs both works, and criterion B2 assesses it directly.

iSWIM for Paper 2. Use the five guiding questions on every prompt.

i	What is the issue of significance? The concern beneath the prompt's topic word.
S	Why does it matter? The human, social or philosophical stakes.
W	What does each author want you to understand about it?
I	How does each author get you to understand it? Structure, form, characterisation, voice, staging.
M	What does each work position its audience towards, and what does the comparison reveal? The essay-level M comes from the tension between M(A) and M(B).

Write each paragraph with PEACE ACT: Point, Evidence, Analysis, Comparison, Extension, Audience, Context, Tie-back. Characters do not exist: reach through the characters to the choices the writer makes with them.

iSWIM tells you how to plan. Thinking with iSWIM tells you how to think. Your text-type guide tells you what to notice and what to call it.

Context

Facts about the writer and period are attributed to a named source. Facts about the work come from the work.

Composition and publication

Orwell wrote the novel in the late 1940s, partly on the island of Jura, while seriously ill; it was published in 1949, and he died in January 1950.

Source: Biographical record (e.g. D. J. Taylor, Orwell: The Life, 2003)

Totalitarianism

The novel draws on Orwell's knowledge of Stalin's Soviet Union and Nazi Germany, and on his experience of propaganda during the Spanish Civil War and at the BBC during the Second World War.

Source: Biographical record; Orwell, "Why I Write" (1946)

At a glance

Chapter	Setting	Events	Event titles
Chapter 1.1	Victory Mansions; the diary; the Two Minutes Hate	E1–E2	A bright cold day; The diary and the Hate
Chapter 1.2	The Parsons' flat; the dream of O'Brien	E3–E3	The Parsons and the place with no darkness
Chapter 1.3	Dreams; the Physical Jerks; the past	E4–E4	Controlling the past
Chapter 1.4	The Records Department	E5–E5	The Records Department
Chapter 1.5	Lunch with Syme	E6–E6	Syme and Newspeak
Chapter 1.7	The proles; the photograph	E7–E7	The proles and two plus two
Chapter 1.8	The prole quarter; Mr Charrington's shop	E8–E8	Mr Charrington's shop
Chapter 2.1	Julia's note	E9–E9	Julia's note
Chapter 2.2	The Golden Country	E10–E10	The Golden Country
Chapter 2.8	O'Brien's flat	E11–E11	O'Brien's flat
Chapter 2.9	Goldstein's book	E12–E12	Goldstein's book
Chapter 2.10	The arrest	E13–E13	The arrest
Chapter 3.2	Torture	E14–E14	How many fingers
Chapter 3.3	O'Brien's doctrine	E15–E15	Power for its own sake
Chapter 3.5	Room 101	E16–E16	Room 101
Chapter 3.6	The Chestnut Tree Café	E17–E17	The Chestnut Tree Café

Event bank

17 numbered events in order. Read one chapter for close revision, or E1 to E17 straight through as the arc of the whole work.

Chapter 1.1

E1 A bright cold day 1.1 (0–5%)

The novel opens with clocks striking thirteen 1.1 (0%) and posters announcing surveillance 1.1 (5%).

Why it matters. The ordinary is made strange from the first sentence.

Dig deeper. What is unsettling about a clock striking thirteen?

E2 The diary and the Hate 1.1 (45–95%)

Winston starts a diary, attends the Two Minutes Hate against Emmanuel Goldstein 1.1 (55%), and finds he has written "DOWN WITH BIG BROTHER" over and over 1.1 (95%).

Why it matters. The first act of rebellion is writing.

Chapter 1.2

E3 The Parsons and the place with no darkness 1.2 (5–95%)

Winston helps his neighbour Mrs Parsons, whose children play at being spies 1.2 (5%). He remembers a voice in a dream promising a meeting in the place where there is no darkness 1.2 (60%). He knows he is already a dead man 1.2 (95%).

Why it matters. The family has become an arm of the state.

Chapter 1.3

E4 Controlling the past 1.3 (70%)

Winston reflects on the Party slogan about the past 1.3 (70%) and on doublethink 1.3 (70%).

Why it matters. The novel's central mechanism: history is whatever the Party says it is.

Chapter 1.4

E5 The Records Department 1.4 (5–85%)

Winston rewrites old newspapers and drops originals into the memory hole 1.4 (5%); he invents a war hero, Comrade Ogilvy, who never existed 1.4 (85%).

Why it matters. Winston is a writer of lies, and good at it.

Dig deeper. Is Winston an opponent of the Party or one of its craftsmen?

Chapter 1.5

E6 Syme and Newspeak 1.5 (0–25%)

Syme, a philologist, explains that Newspeak is meant to narrow the range of thought 1.5 (25%).

Why it matters. Language is the Party's deepest weapon.

Chapter 1.7

E7 The proles and two plus two 1.7 (0–100%)

Winston writes that if there is hope it lies in the proles 1.7 (0%), and that freedom is the freedom to say two plus two make four 1.7 (100%).

Why it matters. Freedom is defined as the right to state the obvious.

Chapter 1.8

E8 Mr Charrington's shop 1.8 (80%)

In the prole quarter Winston buys a glass paperweight with coral inside 1.8 (80%) from Mr Charrington and learns a fragment of the rhyme "Oranges and lemons" 1.8 (75%).

Why it matters. Objects and rhymes from the past become symbols of a world the Party has erased.

Chapter 2.1

E9 Julia's note 2.1 (5–25%)

A girl from the Fiction Department 2.1 (5%) slips Winston a note reading "I love you" 2.1 (25%).

Why it matters. Love arrives as an act of rebellion.

Chapter 2.2

E10 The Golden Country 2.2 (65–100%)

Winston and Julia meet in the countryside, a place he recognises from dreams 2.2 (65%). Their sex is a political act 2.2 (100%).

Why it matters. Desire becomes resistance.

Dig deeper. Is love in the novel private, or always political?

Chapter 2.8

E11 O'Brien's flat 2.8 (45%)

O'Brien receives them and they swear to do anything for the Brotherhood, including throwing sulphuric acid in a child's face 2.8 (45%).

Why it matters. The rebels commit themselves to the Party's own methods.

Chapter 2.9

E12 Goldstein's book 2.9 (10–55%)

Winston reads Goldstein's book, which explains the structure of Oceanian society 2.9 (10%); the best books, he thinks, tell you what you already know 2.9 (55%).

Why it matters. The theory confirms but does not change anything.

Chapter 2.10

E13 The arrest 2.10 (45–100%)

Winston and Julia say "We are the dead"; an iron voice from a hidden telescreen replies 2.10 (50%). The paperweight is smashed 2.10 (75%), and Mr Charrington is revealed as the Thought Police.

Why it matters. Their private space was never private.

Chapter 3.2

E14 How many fingers 3.2 (50%)

In the Ministry of Love, O'Brien tortures Winston until he will see as many fingers as the Party says 3.2 (50%).

Why it matters. Truth is replaced by obedience inside Winston's mind.

Chapter 3.3

E15 Power for its own sake 3.3 (20–70%)

O'Brien explains that the Party seeks power for its own sake 3.3 (20%), that power is inflicting pain and humiliation 3.3 (45%), and offers his image of the future 3.3 (55%). Winston is the last man 3.3 (70%).

Why it matters. The novel's darkest statement of what totalitarian power wants.

Chapter 3.5

E16 Room 101 3.5 (10–90%)

In Room 101 Winston faces the worst thing in the world 3.5 (15%), rats, and betrays Julia 3.5 (90%).

Why it matters. The last loyalty is broken.

Chapter 3.6

E17 The Chestnut Tree Café 3.6 (0–100%)

Released, Winston drinks gin, traces 2+2=5 in the dust 3.6 (30%), meets Julia who says she betrayed him 3.6 (45%), and ends loving Big Brother 3.6 (100%).

Why it matters. The novel ends in total defeat.

Dig deeper. Is there any hope in the ending, or in the Appendix that follows it?

Characters

Winston Smith

A Party member in the Records Department 1.4 (25%).

- Keeps a diary 1.1 (95%).
- Loves Julia 2.2 (100%).
- Betrays her 3.5 (90%).

Arc. From secret dissent to love of Big Brother.

Julia

Works in the Fiction Department 2.1 (5%).

- Sends the note 2.1 (25%).
- Rebels through pleasure rather than theory.
- Betrays Winston 3.6 (45%).

Arc. Practical rebel, broken like Winston.

O'Brien

A member of the Inner Party.

- Appears in Winston's dream 1.2 (60%).
- Swears them into the Brotherhood 2.8 (45%).
- Tortures Winston and explains power 3.3 (20%).

Arc. The tempter and the torturer.

Syme and Parsons

Colleagues.

- Syme explains Newspeak 1.5 (25%) and vanishes.
- The Parsons' children are trained informers 1.2 (5%).

Arc. Loyalty does not protect anyone.

Mr Charrington

The shopkeeper in the prole quarter *1.8 (80%)*.

- Sells the paperweight.
- Is revealed as the Thought Police 2.10 (100%).

Arc. The past turns out to be a trap.

Issues

Each issue is traced through the work. Quotation numbers refer to the quote bank.

Power and totalitarian control

The Party's power is total and openly without purpose beyond itself.

Part 1	Slogans fuse contradictions 1.1 (15%). Quotations: Q1, Q3, Q7
Part 2	The Brotherhood is willing to use terror 2.8 (45%). Quotations: Q17
Part 3	O'Brien explains power for its own sake 3.3 (20%) and the boot 3.3 (55%). Quotations: Q20, Q21, Q22, Q23, Q25, Q29

The whole arc. Power is revealed step by step until its purpose is simply power.

> **Dig deeper**
>
> - Why does O'Brien tell Winston the truth about the Party's motives?

Surveillance and privacy

Surveillance is everywhere and internalised.

Part 1	The poster and the telescreen 1.1 (5%); thought itself is the crime 1.2 (95%). Quotations: Q2, Q5
Part 2	The room above the shop seems safe until the telescreen speaks 2.10 (50%). Quotations: Q19
Part 3	The Ministry of Love finishes the job inside Winston's mind 3.2 (50%). Quotations: –

The whole arc. The surveillance that begins outside ends inside Winston.

> **Dig deeper**
>
> - How does surveillance change behaviour even when no one is watching?

Language and thought

Language shapes what can be thought; Newspeak aims to make dissent impossible.

Part 1	Syme explains Newspeak 1.5 (25%); freedom is a sentence about arithmetic 1.7 (100%).

	Quotations: Q3, Q8, Q10, Q12
Part 2	Goldstein's book tells Winston what he already knows 2.9 (55%). Quotations: Q18
Part 3	Winston writes 2+2=5 3.6 (30%). Quotations: Q27

The whole arc. Winston's freedom ends when his sentences change.

> **Dig deeper**
>
> - Can thought exist without words for it? Compare Orwell's essay "Politics and the English Language".

Memory, history and truth

The Party controls the past by controlling records and memory.

Part 1	Winston rewrites the past for a living 1.4 (5%); the paperweight holds a piece of it 1.8 (80%). Quotations: Q7, Q8, Q9, Q13, Q14
Part 2	The room above the shop is a museum of the past, until it is smashed 2.10 (75%). Quotations: –
Part 3	Winston accepts that the past is what the Party says. Quotations: –

The whole arc. Memory is the last private property, and it is confiscated.

> **Dig deeper**
>
> - Who controls the past in your own society?

Love, sex and loyalty

Love and sex are forms of rebellion, and their betrayal is the Party's final victory.

Part 1	The Party regulates sex; Winston remembers his loveless marriage to Katharine 1.6 (20%). Quotations: –
Part 2	Julia's note 2.1 (25%) and their political act 2.2 (100%). Quotations: Q15, Q16
Part 3	Room 101 breaks loyalty 3.5 (90%); Julia admits the same 3.6 (45%). Quotations: Q26, Q28

The whole arc. Love is what the Party must destroy last.

Dig deeper

- Is Winston's love for Julia genuine, or a form of rebellion against the Party?

The individual and resistance

Winston is the last man; his resistance is small, private and doomed.

Part 1	The diary 1.1 (95%). Quotations: Q4, Q12
Part 2	The affair and the Brotherhood. Quotations: Q16
Part 3	He is named the last man 3.3 (70%) and ends loving Big Brother 3.6 (100%). Quotations: Q20, Q24, Q27, Q29

The whole arc. The novel tracks the elimination of an individual.

Dig deeper

- Does Winston ever genuinely resist, or was he always O'Brien's project?

Hope and despair

Hope recurs, in the proles, the past and love, and is extinguished.

Part 1	Hope in the proles 1.7 (0%). Quotations: Q6, Q11, Q13
Part 2	Hope in the Brotherhood and the book. Quotations: –
Part 3	The image of the future 3.3 (55%). Quotations: Q23, Q24

The whole arc. Some readers find hope only in the Appendix's past tense.

Dig deeper

- Is Nineteen Eighty-Four a prophecy or a warning?

Issue and chapter grid

Reading a row from left to right gives that issue's arc.

Issue	Part 1	Part 2	Part 3
Power and totalitarian control	Q1, Q3, Q7	Q17	Q20, Q21, Q22, Q23, Q25, Q29
Surveillance and privacy	Q2, Q5	Q19	
Language and thought	Q3, Q8, Q10, Q12	Q18	Q27
Memory, history and truth	Q7, Q8, Q9, Q13, Q14		
Love, sex and loyalty		Q15, Q16	Q26, Q28
The individual and resistance	Q4, Q12	Q16	Q20, Q24, Q27, Q29
Hope and despair	Q6, Q11, Q13		Q23, Q24

Orwell’s methods

AO3: how the writer creates meanings and effects through language, structure and form.

Close third-person narration

Everything is seen through Winston, so the reader shares his partial knowledge and his surprise at the arrest 2.10 (50%).

Defamiliarisation

The first sentence makes a normal day strange 1.1 (0%).

Embedded documents

The diary, the slogans, Goldstein’s book 2.9 (10%) and the Appendix give the novel several voices.

Symbolic objects

The paperweight 1.8 (80%) and the rhyme 1.8 (75%) carry the lost past.

The Appendix

“The Principles of Newspeak” is written in the past tense App (0%), which some readers take as a sign that the regime did not last.

Dig deeper

The surface overview is in the event bank and issue arcs. These sections go further: the novel's politics, language and thought, memory and history, the body and love, and the Appendix. Every claim about the novel is referenced; critical readings are offered for evaluation.

Power for its own sake

On the surface. The Party wants control.

O'Brien's explanation strips power of any ideal 3.3 (20%). It could be argued that this is the novel's most original claim: that totalitarianism is not a corrupted ideology but the pursuit of power itself 3.3 (45%).

> **Questions to explore**
>
> - Is O'Brien telling the truth about the Party, or performing one more lie?

Language and thought

On the surface. The Party uses slogans.

Orwell's essay "Politics and the English Language" (1946) argues that slovenly language makes foolish thoughts easier. Newspeak takes this to the extreme 1.5 (25%), and the novel tests whether thought can survive without words 1.7 (100%).

> **Questions to explore**
>
> - Can a language make some thoughts impossible?

Memory, history and truth

On the surface. The Party rewrites records.

The memory hole 1.4 (5%) and the slogan about the past 1.3 (70%) make history a tool of power. It could be argued that Winston's rebellion is fundamentally historical: an attempt to prove the past existed.

> **Questions to explore**
>
> - Why does the Party care about the past at all?

The body, love and the limits of resistance

On the surface. Winston and Julia rebel.

Their rebellion is bodily and private 2.2 (100%); the Party breaks it through the body 3.5 (15%). Critics have debated whether Julia is a fully realised character or a projection of Winston's desires.

> **Questions to explore**
>
> - Why does the Party need to break love, not only stop rebellion?

The Appendix and the question of hope

On the surface. The novel ends in defeat.

The Appendix describes Newspeak in the past tense App (0%). Some readers, following Margaret Atwood, see this as a quiet sign that the regime eventually fell; others treat it as a scholarly convention.

> **Questions to explore**
>
> - Does the Appendix change how you read the ending?

Quote bank

29 quotations in order of appearance.

Chapter 1.1

No.	Ref.	Quotation and note
Q1	1.1 (0%)	"clocks were striking thirteen" Normal life subtly wrong. Power and totalitarian control
Q2	1.1 (5%)	"BIG BROTHER IS WATCHING YOU" The novel's most famous slogan. Surveillance and privacy
Q3	1.1 (15%)	"WAR IS PEACE" The Party slogans: contradictions held as truths. Language and thought · Power and totalitarian control
Q4	1.1 (95%)	"DOWN WITH BIG BROTHER" Rebellion written almost without intent. The individual and resistance

Chapter 1.2

No.	Ref.	Quotation and note
Q5	1.2 (95%)	"thoughtcrime IS death" The crime is thinking. Surveillance and privacy
Q6	1.2 (60%)	"the place where there is no darkness" A promise that turns out to mean the lit cells of the Ministry of Love. Hope and despair

Chapter 1.3

No.	Ref.	Quotation and note
Q7	1.3 (70%)	"Who controls the past" The Party's theory of history. Memory · Power and totalitarian control
Q8	1.3 (70%)	"doublethink" The mental discipline of believing contradictions. Language and thought · Memory

Chapter 1.4

No.	Ref.	Quotation and note
Q9	1.4 (5%)	“memory hole” The machinery of forgetting. Memory

Chapter 1.5

No.	Ref.	Quotation and note
Q10	1.5 (25%)	“narrow the range of thought” Newspeak’s purpose. Language and thought

Chapter 1.7

No.	Ref.	Quotation and note
Q11	1.7 (0%)	“If there is hope” Hope placed in the proles. Hope and despair
Q12	1.7 (100%)	“Freedom is the freedom to say that two plus two make four” Freedom as the right to state a fact. The individual and resistance Language and thought

Chapter 1.8

No.	Ref.	Quotation and note
Q13	1.8 (80%)	“glass paperweight” An object from the past, later smashed. Memory Hope and despair
Q14	1.8 (75%)	“Oranges and lemons” A fragment of a lost culture, ending in an executioner. Memory

Chapter 2.1

No.	Ref.	Quotation and note
Q15	2.1 (25%)	“I love you” A note that breaks the law. Love

Chapter 2.2

No.	Ref.	Quotation and note
Q16	2.2 (100%)	“It was a political act” Desire as rebellion. Love · The individual and resistance

Chapter 2.8

No.	Ref.	Quotation and note
Q17	2.8 (45%)	“throw sulphuric acid” The rebels promise atrocities. Power and totalitarian control

Chapter 2.9

No.	Ref.	Quotation and note
Q18	2.9 (55%)	“The best books” Theory that confirms what one knew. Language and thought

Chapter 2.10

No.	Ref.	Quotation and note
Q19	2.10 (50%)	“You are the dead” The telescreen answers. Surveillance and privacy

Chapter 3.2

No.	Ref.	Quotation and note
Q20	3.2 (50%)	“How many fingers” Truth broken by pain. Power and totalitarian control · The individual and resistance

Chapter 3.3

No.	Ref.	Quotation and note
Q21	3.3 (20%)	“for its own sake” Power without ideology. Power and totalitarian control

Q22	3.3 (45%)	“Power is in inflicting pain and humiliation” O’Brien’s definition. Power and totalitarian control
Q23	3.3 (55%)	“a boot stamping on a human face” The image of the future. Power and totalitarian control · Hope and despair
Q24	3.3 (70%)	“the last man” Winston as the last guardian of humanity. The individual and resistance · Hope and despair

Chapter 3.5

No.	Ref.	Quotation and note
Q25	3.5 (15%)	“worst thing in the world” Room 101 is personal. Power and totalitarian control
Q26	3.5 (90%)	“Do it to Julia” The betrayal. Love

Chapter 3.6

No.	Ref.	Quotation and note
Q27	3.6 (30%)	“2+2=5” Winston has learned the lesson. Language and thought · The individual and resistance
Q28	3.6 (45%)	“I betrayed you” Julia’s confession, matching his. Love
Q29	3.6 (100%)	“He loved Big Brother” The last words of the novel proper. Power and totalitarian control · The individual and resistance

Self-test

7 quick questions; answers with references follow.

1. **What does Winston write in his diary?**
   2+2=5 / DOWN WITH BIG BROTHER / I LOVE YOU / WAR IS PEACE
2. **What is Newspeak designed to do?**
   Narrow the range of thought / Record history / Teach children / Translate other languages
3. **What does Winston buy from Mr Charrington?**
   A clock / A diary / A glass paperweight with coral / A painting
4. **What does Julia's note say?**
   Beware O'Brien / Down with Big Brother / I love you / Meet me tonight
5. **Who arrests Winston and Julia?**
   O'Brien alone / Parsons / Syme / The Thought Police, with Mr Charrington
6. **What is in Room 101?**
   A telescreen / Drowning / Fire / The worst thing in the world: for Winston, rats
7. **How does the novel end?**
   Julia is executed / The Party falls / Winston escapes / Winston loves Big Brother

Answers

1. DOWN WITH BIG BROTHER 1.1 (95%)
2. Narrow the range of thought 1.5 (25%)
3. A glass paperweight with coral 1.8 (80%)
4. I love you 2.1 (25%)
5. The Thought Police, with Mr Charrington 2.10 (100%)
6. The worst thing in the world: for Winston, rats 3.5 (15%)
7. Winston loves Big Brother 3.6 (100%)

Sources

- George Orwell, *Nineteen Eighty-Four* (1949), with the Appendix "The Principles of Newspeak".
- LitCharts and SparkNotes on *1984*; Bloom's Guides and Bloom's Critical Views on Orwell.
- George Orwell, "Politics and the English Language" (1946) and "Why I Write" (1946).